

pick of the week



Musical memories

Some voices linger long after the music ends. Kaatril Undhan Geetham celebrates the enduring legacy of S Janaki with an evening of her most-loved songs. Presented by Samagratha Foundation, the tribute brings together singers, artistes from Zee Tamil *SaRiGaMaPa* and a live orchestra. Catch the musical evening on August 9 at Vani Mahal, Chennai. Entry is free; passes are mandatory. *WhatsApp* 6381788551 to know your nearest pass collection point.



Sketching Madras

See Madras through a sketchbook at this walk-and-sketch experience inside the Egmore Museum. Wander through its beautiful heritage buildings, observing their architecture, details and stories before settling down to sketch your favourite views. Designed for beginners and open to all, the guided session offers step-by-step support. *On August 2, 4pm to 6.30pm. Fee ₹1,000; student price ₹750, with all materials provided.*



Catch the killer

Whodunnit, anyone? Step into a room full of suspects at The Last Mic, an interactive murder mystery where every conversation could reveal a clue. Team up, interrogate suspects, connect the dots and see if you can catch the killer before they strike again. No acting experience needed — bring your detective instincts. *August 8, 6.30pm to 8.30pm at Backyard, Adyar. ₹500. Age 18 and above. For booking a spot follow, @thebackyardclan on Instagram.*



Canvas stories

Step into a conversation between three artists as Echoes of the Trio brings together the works of Ezhil Aparajit, Kavitha Aravind and Radha Kannan. Exploring femininity, spirituality and Indian cultural traditions through contemporary and abstract art, the exhibition moves from wildlife-inspired paintings to expressive portraits and textured abstractions. *Till today at Sarala Art Gallery, Teynampet. Open to all.*



THE NAKED TRUTH

Gotta have faith

Religion still shapes who most Indians marry, yet faith-based dating remains surprisingly niche. The answer reveals how India's relationship culture is changing

More Indians want to date casually before marriage. GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK



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Arav's Hinge profile is a masterclass in plausible deniability. Nowhere does the 29-year-old Bengaluru-based IT professional mention that he is a Tamil Brahmin. There is no reference to whether he is an Iyer or an Iyengar, no mention of horoscopes, and certainly no hint that his mother has already begun mentally auditioning potential daughters-in-law. Instead, he leaves behind the sort of clues only the right people are meant to notice: a photograph from Chennai's Margazhi music season, another with a steel tumbler of filter coffee, and a prompt passionately insisting that Mysapore has the city's best sambar.

His parents would prefer he meet someone who belongs to the same community. He doesn't entirely disagree. "Shared traditions matter," he says. "I just don't want to discuss horoscopes before I've figured out whether I even enjoy spending time with someone."

And that, strangely enough, feels like India's dating problem. We have become extraordinarily good at helping people marry within their communities, and have built an entire digital ecosystem around it. In fact,

Matrimony.com alone operates more than 325 community-specific sites, spanning religions, castes, linguistic groups and professions. What we never really figured out was the bit that comes before it. Dating.

Around the block Which is curious because religion still exerts an astonishing influence over whom Indians marry. Pew Research Center, which conducts public opinion surveys in countries outside the US, found that 99% of Hindus, 98% of Muslims, 97% of Sikhs and 95% of Christians marry within their own faith, which makes the absence of faith-based dating apps all the more intriguing.

India has no shortage of faith-based matrimonial websites. But when it comes to faith-based dating, the cupboard has been surprisingly bare. That's what makes Muzz — one of the first global, faith-first dating apps to officially expand into India — so interesting.

The London-born platform occupies the space between Tinder and Shaadi.com. It isn't interested in casual swiping, but neither does it expect your parents to join the conversation before you have decided whether you would like to split desert. Globally, it says it has over 17 million users, and has facilitated more than 800,000 marriages.

For one 28-year-old architect from Mumbai, that middle ground was exactly the appeal. "I thought I'd finally be able to skip the explanatory part on Muzz. If everyone here already understands Ramadan or why I don't drink, maybe we can actually talk about books or films." Instead, she found that shared faith often accelerated the conversation rather than relaxed it. "So many chats felt like someone had opened an Excel sheet. How often do you pray? What's your timeline for marriage? How many children do you want? They're valid questions. They're just not first-date questions," she says.

A 31-year-old Mangalorean Christian describes arriving at the same conclusion from a different direction. Long before algorithms entered the picture, church aunties had already perfected the recommendation engine. She still finds herself gravitating towards other Christians — not because she is unwilling to date outside her faith, but because shared religion sometimes make it easier to crack inside jokes, as trivial as it may sound. "Christmas traditions, family jokes, food, Sunday Mass. You don't have to explain those things."

For years, matrimonial websites were India's default operating system for finding a spouse. For Matrimony.com, its Q3 FY2025 earnings, it reported a "noticeable decline" in new profiles, with paid subscriptions falling 9.7% and matchmaking revenue dipping 4.2%. It has read the room, launching Luv.com, a dating app for working professionals — a tacit acknowledgement that modern Indians don't want to jump straight from "Hi" to horoscope matching.

Which perhaps explains why so many Indians continue using dating apps while signalling identity rather than declaring it outright. India, it seems, hasn't stopped looking for marriage. It has inserted a much longer dating phase before it.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum

Textiles in transition

A celebration of India's textiles, Nayaab arrives with conversations that bridge heritage and contemporary design



Creation by Translate Ikat India; (below) a piece by designer Urvashi Kaur. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Among the featured designers is Urvashi Kaur, whose Renew Project explores the future of textiles through handwoven tussar silk, shibori and leheriya techniques. By repurposing heirloom Benaras textiles into contemporary fabrics and garments, the project extends the life of these treasured weaves through sustainable design.

Rupa also highlights Studio A3 as one of this year's key participants, presenting a special collection celebrating the timeless craft of kantha hand embroidery on natural fabrics such as khadi cotton, linen and silk.

Driven by a mission to revive the extraordinary art of ikat, Hyderabad-based Translate Ikat India is committed to creating meaningful change through its sustained engagement with the indigenous craft of ikat weaving. They will be showcasing their pieces at the exhibition too.

Among the 28 stalls at Nayaab is Naari Shakti: a non-profit initiative based in Okhla Basti, Delhi, that empowers women through craft.

The event will also feature a panel discussion titled Threads of Continuity: Craft, Culture and Contemporary Design on August 8 at 11am.

At Welcome Hotel by ITC Hotels, Cathedral Road. On August 7 and 8 from 10am to 8pm. Prices start at ₹7,000.

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The artisan and master weavers of our country are continually finding ways to incorporate contemporary ideas into their creations, ensuring that the richness of our traditional weaving heritage remains alive and relevant. However, saleability and effective marketing continue to be significant challenges that these artisans must navigate," says Delhi-based textile connoisseur Rupa Sood.

Through Nayaab, founded in 2015, Rupa has built a community of over 150 designers and craftspeople dedicated to preserving, promoting and celebrating India's rich textile traditions and exceptional craftsmanship.



(Left) A jamdani sari by Nilambari; (below) Weavers Studio resist dyeing. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Professor Vishal C Bhand and Bijoya Halder, Beej and Co is a sustainable textile brand based out of Shantiniketan (Bolpur), West Bengal, specialising in handcrafted eco-printed garments.

"We will have saris and stoles, where every piece is one-of-a-kind because we print with flowers and leaves, so the same design can never really be repeated," says Vishal.

Atmesh Selot, the third-generation custodian of Benaras-based Nilambari Silk, founded in 1997, is bringing the brand's traditional Jamdani saris to the showcase. "Our signature collection is the Jamdani of Benaras, which is woven in gold and silver zari and takes nearly three to three-and-a-half months to make, with two to three skilled weavers working on each sari."

"Handlooms are always sustainable. All these yarns are natural; they're not polyester-based yarns. And a sari as a garment is also very recyclable because it doesn't require much fitting or anything. So it can be passed on through generations," says Atmesh.

Other labels to look out for include Abha Dalmia, Blue Lotus, Kapaas, Juanita, Mauna Dhvani, Neelgar, Rangila Dhaga, Rangrez Creation, Studio Rama, Tana Bana Maheshwari Handloom and Tritiya Designs, bringing together everything from Benaras and Maheshwari weaves to bandhani, shibori, gamcha, kalamkari and contemporary handloom garments.

The Crafts Council of India textile exhibition will be held on August 7 and 8, at MRC Centre, 75/2, Santhome High Road.

India in weaves

From Bengal's kantha to Rajasthan's bandhani, the Crafts Council of India brings India's textile heritage to Chennai

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For two days, Chennai will play host to India's vast textile heritage to commemorate Handloom Day (August 7) by turning MRC Centre into a showcase of diverse handicrafts from across the country. From resist-dyeing techniques of bandhani and leheriya to the stitches of kantha and the geometric precision of ikat, the Crafts Council of India (CCI) is bringing together artisans, designers, and techniques that have kept these traditions alive for generations.

Spread across 39 stalls, the exhibition will showcase an array of saris, garments, and handcrafted fabrics, offering visitors a closer look at the people and stories behind the creations.

For Darshan Mekani Shah, founder, Weavers Studio from West Bengal, the



showcase is an opportunity to bring Bengal's rich textile vocabulary to Chennai, with a collection that moves between the traditional and contemporary. Her edit for the exhibition will feature hand-spun and handwoven textiles in khadi, cotton, linen and eri silk alongside Bengal's gamcha and jamdani traditions. The collection will also include Tangail, garod, and Begampuri weaves, paired with vintage-inspired blouses, contemporary

drapes, and traditional block prints drawn from Weaver's Studio's archive of local motifs. The garments range from easy tunics, kaftans, open jackets and co-ord sets to shirts, semi-stitched garments and unstitched sets.

"We wanted to focus on Bengal's woven textiles, but also bring in some of the techniques and motifs that we haven't used for a long time," says Darshan.

Founded in 2020 by husband-and-wife duo



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At the Chamber of Princes in Jaipur’s Rambagh Palace, the morning light slips through carved *jaalis* and settles across marble floors. Delicate filigree curls around doorways, *chhatris* punctuate the palace skyline beyond the windows. Outside, peacocks wander the lawns with the soft entitlement of permanent residents.

By the time watchmaker and founder of Jaipur Watch Company, Gaurav Mehta, lifts the lid off his newest watches, it becomes difficult to tell where the palace ends and the timepieces begin.

The city as the blueprint
This was perhaps why the Jaipur Watch Company chose Rambagh Palace to unveil its newest collections, Premium Baagh and Gates of India. The *jaalis*, *chhatris*, and filigree have found expression on the dials of the watches resting inside velvet-lined boxes, revealing the architectural vocabulary from which Gaurav Mehta’s designs emerged.

Both collections were designed in consultation with Gaurav’s design team in Jaipur, with the watch straps crafted in Indian leather.

Prior to the launch , the company drove us through the Pink City’s walled precincts to the City Palace, stopping before the ornate gateways of Pritam Niwas Chowk, the Lotus Gate, and Leheriya Gate to reveal how the architecture of the gates had spilled onto the dials of the watches.

For Gaurav, this was less a design exercise than a return to the city that has shaped and inspired almost every watch he has made. “Jaipur is known beyond jewellery. It is known for its history, its palaces and its architecture. We are a watch company. We have never wanted to become a jewellery brand. We wanted to tell Jaipur’s stories through watches,” says Gaurav.

That philosophy has guided the company since its founding in 2013. Long before Indian microbrands became fashionable, the company built its identity around Indian narratives rather than Swiss imitation.



Jaipur on my wrist

The Pink City’s palace *chhatris*, ornate gates, and the iconic tiger turn into wearable art in Jaipur Watch Company’s latest luxury watch collections

Ancient coins like the Indian 4 anas, 50 paisa and 1 rupee became dials, and painted miniatures found their way onto watch faces. Sandstone, Rajput jewellery, Mughal motifs, and now architecture, have all been translated into mechanical objects worn on the wrist.

Today, the company describes itself as India’s first

micro luxury watch brand. Last year it sold around 10,000 watches. This financial year it hopes to cross 20,000. The growth has been gradual, and, Gaurav insists, painfully slow. “It took us almost nine years just to survive. Consumers weren’t there. Manufacturers weren’t



(Clockwise from above) The Lotus gate in Jaipur; a watch from the Gates of India Collection; founder Gaurav Mehta; a blue khadi embossed watch from the Premium Baagh Collection; a turquoise dial watch from the Premium Baagh collection; the Roman Baagh watch. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND SHREYA BANERJEE

supportive. Retailers weren’t interested. The only thing that kept me going was making these watches,” recalls the founder.

That persistence received an unexpected endorsement late last year. In November 2025, photographs surfaced of Prime Minister Narendra Modi wearing what appeared to be one of the company’s Baagh watches.

Gaurav had no idea until someone called to say the timepiece looked familiar. “We went through the Prime Minister’s official photo gallery. He wears his watch on the inside of his wrist, so it wasn’t easy to identify. But I

recognised our logo and the distinctive lugs. Then I knew,” says Gaurav, smiling.

At its heart is an original 1947 one rupee coin bearing India’s iconic walking tiger which is a nod to the year of Independence and the country’s emergence into a new identity.

Housed in a 43 mm 316L stainless steel case, the Roman Baagh is powered by a Japanese Miyota automatic movement, with sapphire crystals on both sides, a transparent case back, and 5 ATM water resistance (which means it is safe for shallow swimming up to 50 metres).

Priced between ₹55,000 and ₹60,000, it positions itself as an accessible luxury timepiece rooted in Indian history and craftsmanship.

The photographs quickly circulated online, sending enquiries and searches for the small Jaipur brand soaring.

For Gaurav, the moment represented something larger. “I think it sent a message that if you are honestly building something in India, there is support,” he notes.

Yet the watches themselves resist becoming symbols of nationalism alone, they remain intensely local.

The roar of the tiger
The Premium Baagh evokes the symbolism of the tiger which stands for courage and also aligns with India’s Make in India logo.

Its offset dial is wrapped in genuine muslin khadi, bordered by intricate court-inspired filigree, and crowned with a miniature Rajput chhatra set with a ruby jewel. Beneath sits a natural stone dial, turquoise, tiger eye, aventurine or abalone depending on the variant while a Swiss Sellita or Japanese Miyota automatic movement powers the watch.

Each case is individually CNC-milled (computer controlled cutting) from 316L stainless steel with engraved flanks and custom turquoise stone inlays integrated into the lugs, the movement of the

watch visible through an exhibition caseback that reveals its inner working alongside an etched tiger motif.

Priced at approximately ₹1,65,000, each piece requires roughly seven weeks to complete.

Open the gates
If Baagh borrows from Nature, Gates of India borrows from Jaipur. The watch carries two movements and can be flipped, allowing wearers to display separate time zones on either face.

One side is playful and colourful, the other restrained and monochromatic. Flip the watch over and its personality changes, much like walking through Jaipur’s gates into different neighbourhoods.

The collection also completes a full circle . Since 2013, Jaipur Watch Company’s logo has consisted of four arches positioned at twelve, three, six and nine o’clock.

Most customers recognise them simply as a logo. Few realise they are lifted directly from the arched crowns that sit atop Jaipur’s historic city gates. “Our logo always carried the identity of those gates. People just never noticed,” smiles Gaurav.

His fascination with Jaipur’s urban planning began in school, when he was assigned a history project requiring him to hand-draw a map of Jaipur’s walled city.

“That’s when I realised how brilliantly planned the city was. Everything connected. There was so much architectural thinking behind it,” recalls Gaurav with a glint in his eye. Those lessons have lived on long after school.

Planning for the future
When discussing future ambitions, developing Indian made movements, opening 100 stores over the next three years and expanding internationally, Gaurav repeatedly returns to the same idea: watches as conversation starters, “You’re not just wearing a watch. You’re carrying a story about India.”

The hands of the watch move to the rhythm of Jaipur’s gateways, peacocks and pink sandstone.

The writer was in Jaipur on invitation from the Jaipur Watch Company

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India’s bars are making their presence felt in Asia’s cocktail circuit, and the recently concluded Asia’s 50 Best Bars 2026 ceremony is proof.

Earlier this week, at a glittering evening in Macau, the coveted list was unveiled before industry professionals.

The 50 bars spanned 22 cities, with 14 new entries this year. While China’s Hope & Sesame from Guangzhou took the number one spot, three Indian bars, Boilermaker, SOKA, and Bar Spirit Forward, made the cut, with Bengaluru taking two spots, retaining its status as the bar capital of the country (well, I may be a little biased). While all are familiar names, and no new winners emerged from the country, it is a testament to creativity and consistency.

Hope & Sesame is a hidden speakeasy located behind a Cantonese store in the historic Dongshankou district. Founders Bastien Ciocca and Andrew Ho play with techniques such as centrifugal clarification, sous vide infusions, and rotary distillation, to marry tradition and innovation.

China won seven spots on the list this year, its highest ever, proof that it has a fast-growing cocktail scene that is embracing new trends.

Bangkok won eight spots on the list, cementing its position as a powerhouse, with Dry Wave Cocktail Studio, BKK Social Club and



An Indian bucket list

What does it take for an Indian bar to make it to Asia’s 50 Best Bars list? We meet the mixologists behind the winners

Opium. Hong Kong was another clear winner with seven bars, such as Bar Leone, Shelley Tai and Montana. Singapore, Seoul and Jakarta secured four spots each.

A shack in sleepy Siolim
Goa’s Boilermaker came in at number eight on the list, cracking the coveted top 10 spot. It was also awarded The Best Bar in India. Boilermaker embodies the laid-back ‘susegad’ spirit of Goa. Something that co-founder Pankaj Balachandran feels contributes to its success. “Even if it’s not air-conditioned, even if there are no leather seats or fancy trimmings, you can still build

something world-class because the soul of a bar comes from the experience you create for every guest. If you take care of the most important parts – your people, genuine hospitality, and a product you’re proud of, then the space becomes whatever you make it.”

The menu is heavy on Goan ingredients, like the Biso Manana Karamel, which is made with local spirit, dukshiri.

Bengaluru in a glass
At number 18 is a Bengaluru darling, SOKA. Helmed by Chef Sombir Choudhary and bartender Avinash Kapoli (hence SO and KA) this one is

located in Indiranagar.

The bar was at number 28 last year and has now entered the top 20. The cocktails at SOKA capture the local Bengaluru flavour, nostalgia, lingo and ingredients.

Black Cadillac is a drink named after a popular pub from the ‘90s and Cheese Cherry Pineapple is a tribute to the snacks at Downtown Pub, another old favourite.

“The F&B community is incredibly close-knit. Whether or not a bar made the list this year, the support for one another has remained unwavering. That is the real strength of the industry,” says Sombir.

“For Bengaluru, I think the

(Clockwise from left) Bar Spirit Forward; a cocktail at Boilermaker; and Avinash and Sombir of Soka. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



most exciting phase is still ahead. The city no longer needs to imitate the established cocktail capitals of the world. It has its own identity, ingredients, talent and audience. What we need now are more bars with a distinct point of view.”

Craft and technique
Moving up from number 37 to number 30 is another Bengaluru establishment, Bar Spirit Forward. As the official 50 Best Bar website describes

it, the bar focusses on creating a buzzy atmosphere that is punctuated by technically sound cocktails.

Co-founded by Arijit Bose (his Goa establishment Bar Outrigger came in at number 51), this one is loved for its atmosphere that feels straight out of New York. The Southern Star cocktail, a tequila and fermented fruit blend, is a must-try.

“Once you are in the list you are among giants of the industry, so going up there is both amazing and it also creates a bit of pressure to do better. Our team and our loyal patrons are invested in what we are and proud of our achievements so that always makes us happy. But there is still a lot to do and a long way to go,” he says.

While last year, five Indian bars had made the cut, and this year only three did, the wins are indicative of the sustained effort and artistry of these establishments.

Asia’s Best Bars 2026

1. Hope & Sesame, Guangzhou
2. Zest, Seoul
3. Bar Leone, Hong Kong
4. Dry Wave Cocktail Studio, Bangkok
5. MO Bar Shenzhen, Shenzhen
6. Bar Us, Bangkok
7. Lennon’s, Bangkok
8. Boilermaker, Goa
9. Jigger & Pony, Singapore
10. Obsidian Bar, Shenzhen
11. Modernhaus, Jakarta
12. Nutmeg & Clove, Singapore
13. Alice, Seoul
14. Vender, Taichung
15. Cosmo Pony, Jakarta
16. Offtrack, Singapore
17. Bar Sathorn, Bangkok
18. Soka, Bengaluru



19. Pony Up, Shanghai
20. BKK Social Club, Bangkok
21. Carrots Bar, Jakarta
22. Gokan, Hong Kong
23. Punch Room Tokyo, Tokyo
24. Coa, Hong Kong
25. Opium, Bangkok
26. Virtu, Tokyo
27. CMYK, Changsha
28. Ralph’s Bar, Chengdu
29. Smao & Bitters, Hiriketiya
30. Bar Spirit Forward, Bengaluru

▼
Textile tales

Slow fashion takes centrestage at Loom's Lullaby – The Song of the Loom, a showcase by Maku Textiles at The Amethyst Room. Founded in Kolkata in 2011 by Santanu Das, the label is known for reimagining India's textile traditions through contemporary silhouettes crafted from handwoven fabrics and natural, azo-free dyes. Browse a collection of womenswear including tunics, pyjamas, trousers, saris, and scarves, alongside a curated menswear selection. Inspired by the rhythm of the loom, this collection unfolds in indigo and crisp white, celebrating craftsmanship, and heritage. The pieces are made in collaboration with rural artisans, showcasing the brand's commitment to preserving traditional weaving with mindful fashion. *August 5 to 9, 10.30am to 7.30pm, The Amethyst Room, RA Puram. Prices start at ₹14,000.*



▼
At the farmers' market

Fresh bread, farm produce, pantry staples, and plenty of small-batch treats await visitors at the Chennai Artisans & Farmers Market on August 1. Fill your bags with sourdough from Nido Bakery and School, matcha from House of Nagomi, old-school bakes by Moon Rabbit Cakes, handcrafted jams from 101 Strawberries, creamy nut butters by Winzy Gourmet, artisanal cheese from Oh Cheese, fresh produce from My Harvest Farms, organic essentials by Earth Sense Farms, and eco-friendly finds from Kamalam. You can also browse sauces from Spicy by Surya, snack bars by O My Bar, ice creams from Shmoozies, coffee at Romancham Cafe, and Kerala favourites by Achayathis. Meet the makers, sample local flavours, and shop directly from independent brands.
At Hanu Reddy Residences, Poes Garden, from 11am to 9pm. Entry is free.

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(Clockwise from right) Stills from the film; Tom Holland and Destin Daniel Cretton during the filming. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



wonder

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A timid boy with an accidental spider bite caught everyone's on-screen attention at the turn of the century. Slinging across the high-rises of New York, the boy's steady descent into a masked vigilante donning a vibrant red and blue suit became an epitome of morality for a new generation. Spider-Man transformed the boy, Peter Parker, into a version he never imagined. It was a clever mix of fantasy and realism; Parker's ordinariness was easy to identify with, but it was Spider-Man's enhanced abilities that teased the limits of imagination. The web-slinger's first on-screen appearance in 2002 enthused all, including Destin Daniel Cretton, the director of the upcoming, *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*.
"It was quite an experience to feel the rush of what it would be like to have those powers," Cretton tells *The Hindu* over a virtual call as he recalls



Destin Daniel Cretton, director of *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*, talks about making independent human dramas, Marvel superhero films, and how he looks at the hero's journey

being filled with joy watching Tobey Maguire turn into Spider-Man. "He is a superhero who is dealing with problems in high school with his classmates bullying him. I could relate to him a lot. So, being able to make a *Spider-Man* film for a new generation of young people is like a dream for me," he says.
There is a tint of that warm orange from the 2002 film in *Brand New Day*, which adds a reviving sense of nostalgia even as the world it inhabits is far more advanced. Being the fourth part in the franchise in which Tom Holland portrays the superhero, the film is virtually a reset of the story as Parker loses his identity and walks like a stranger in his home city, with many familiar faces but none that recognise him. This leads to moments of vulnerability that balance the over-the-top action. Even for Cretton, his love for the character stems from the humanity that lies inside the superhero.
"What fascinates me are his imperfections and how he continues to make big mistakes but never stops trying to be better. This time, Peter has no one to lean on, not even Tony Stark. To watch him learn the importance of connection and community appealed to me a lot," says the filmmaker.

Cretton's attraction to the human condition is not coincidental. Before he turned to Marvel films with *Shang-Chi and the Legend of the Ten Rings* (2021), the director's work was steeped in stirring realities, whether it was exploring the life of troubled teenagers in his independent feature, *Short Term 12*, or his adaptation of American author Jeannette Walls' memoir, *The Glass Castle*, in 2017. From these emotive human dramas to the superhero spectacle, the genre shift is apparent. Cretton says that the experience was "different but not that different at the same time".
"In *Shang-Chi* and *Spider-Man*, there were way more people working on set and the scale was huge. The emphasis on action was new to me. But it also felt familiar because in these big action movies, it becomes more important to capture the heart, drama and comedy that happens between the action."
Working on *Shang-Chi* was a learning experience in that direction for him. "What makes the big spectacle work is making sure that you keep the audience focussed on the characters and their personal journeys. If that journey feels intimate and grounded, then the spectacle works even better," he adds.
There is a conscious emphasis on the hero's journey in *Brand New Day* as Parker tackles his inner emotions in a major shift in the franchise where his loneliness gets a

thorough release. That way, a similarity could be drawn between Shang-Chi and Spider-Man in how both navigate their powers as young superheroes carrying extraordinary responsibilities. Interestingly, Cretton will also be helming a live-action adaptation of the popular Japanese manga series, *Naruto*, where again a similar thematic strain runs through. In that case, what are Cretton's thoughts on hero's journey?
"I try not to overthink it even though I studied it in school. What I constantly chase are characters that I relate to and with whom I can go on a journey from start to end," he says. The filmmaker tries to understand these characters through the lens of his own personal life, elaborating how some things inside him make him feel different from other people, whether it is anxiety, shyness and social awkwardness – all of which embarrasses him on occasions.
"But when I allow myself to accept, embrace and celebrate them, they are the things that then help me connect with other people. They make my art better too," he says and concludes, "That's the journey that Shang-Chi was on and that's what Peter Parker is on. They learn eventually that things that they potentially see as weaknesses are the exact things that become their strength."

Spiderman: Brand New Day is currently running in theatres.



(Clockwise from left) Stills from the series, James Norton as Ormund Hightower in *House of the Dragon* Season 3. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



monumental set like the one in *House of the Dragon* was humbling. The Tumbleton set, which was built in a back lot in Leavesden Studios, was massive, like a town in itself." Apart from the scale of the production, Norton says, there is also the loyalty of the fans.
Norton thought he should learn as much about Westeros as the most diehard fan, "As an actor, that can be quite dangerous because too much information and research can paralyse you, as you then want to show everything all at once."

Human story
It is the same as when researching a role, Norton says, "If you're playing a soldier in the Second World War, there is an infinite amount of research you can do. But when you're playing

the character, you have to throw it all away, and all you're playing is the human story. And in that moment, you realise it is just like the smallest job you've ever done. The one day's work you did on the tiny soap opera or the first job you ever did is exactly the same as what Ormund in *House of the Dragon*."

When the levee breaks
For all Ormund's tight control, there are moments when it snaps, like it does in episode 4. "The scene between Daeron and me was intense. It was an important scene because it showed what Ormund is dealing with internally. The scene explored where that rage came from."
The scene, Norton says, shows what happens when Ormund loses control. "When I was smashing that table I was so full of adrenaline, that I nearly fainted," Norton says laughing. "I had to call 'Cut' because when you're telling your body and mind to go into a state of fury the moment they call 'Action', it gets confused."

Nought to 60
At one point, Norton says, "I had no idea where I was. That was quite a hard scene to come down from because you're literally going from nought to 60. I had to take a moment, have a cup of tea, and a couple of paracetamol because my head was really painful by the end (*laughs*)."

Villain or hero
"As an actor, my responsibility is to forget the show, and the meta narrative of the piece, and just think about what my story is and how I'm relating to these people and circumstances," he says.
Morality in that moment, Norton says, is incredibly subjective.

House of the Dragon Season 3 is currently streaming on JioHotstar



The fate of fire

James Norton talks of the importance of the human story, the dangers of too much research, and how Ormund's sensitivity to smell was a powerful hook into the character

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Season 3 of *House of the Dragon* introduces a new antagonist, Ormund Hightower, played with controlled ferocity by James Norton. Ormund is a particular adversary for Rhaenyra (Emma D'Arcy), Norton says over a video call from London.
Page to screen
In terms of inspiration for Ormund, the 41-year-old *Grantchester* actor says there was not much in the book (George R.R. Martin's *Fire & Blood*). "He is described lightly. It was fun because it was a blank canvas, and we were given permission to fill in a lot of the gaps. Ryan (Condal, showrunner) modelled Ormund on a proper English gentleman with a dark, twisted edge," he says.
Preferring not to lean on other performances as it could lead to mimicking, Norton says, he enjoyed the creators' permission to go big and bold

with Ormund.
Sense and sensitivity
Ormund's sensitivity to smell was a hook. "If someone is that sensitive to smell and that terrified of its power, he is constantly on the edge. There is a tightness, paranoia and fear undercutting everything. It is almost like every sinew of my body was ever so slightly taut all the time, which was a helpful thing to play with as an actor," says Norton.
Making an odd man
"The costume and the props departments gave me this incredible costume. My armor and sword were so ornate and beautifully crafted, that it was almost like Ormund had gone to the blacksmith himself and specified exactly what he wanted. The props department would spray my pomander with lavender oil. We collaborated with different departments to make this odd man," he says.
What lies beneath
We first see Ormund's duplicity in episode 3. "There

was a moment when Ormund is facing up to Daemon (Matt Smith) and he hands over Daeron, or who we think is Daeron. If you were to re-watch that, I would hope that some of the audience would see a little hint of the lie, which Daemon doesn't," adds Norton.
The challenge, Norton says, is to find that subtle, small space where you're inviting the audience in, but not obvious enough to let the lie be known to your scene partner. "Ormund is aware that he's going to take Tumbleton. He's not giving up the fight. He's obviously lying to Daemon, when promising allegiance and fealty to Rhaenyra," he quips.
Big or small
Stepping into a large, well-loved franchise such as *House of the Dragon* does not require a change in approach, Norton comments. "Walking onto a

K-Drama homecoming

Over 100 K-Dramas, also dubbed in Hindi, Tamil and Telugu, will roll out on Prime Video India



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In a deal that will see more than 100 K-Drama titles roll out on the streaming platform over the next two years, Prime Video India and Korean entertainment company CJ ENM have entered into a multi-year distribution partnership. Earlier this week, representatives from both organisations convened at Mumbai to make the announcement.
This includes a slate of 26 original titles – a mix of K-Dramas, unscripted offerings from CJ ENM, as well as a host of other popular shows such as the breakout K-Drama *The Legend of Kitchen Soldier*, *Prison Playbook*, *Search: WWW*, *Dear X*, *Study Group*, *Law In The City*, and *My Dearest Nemesis*.
All new and upcoming titles will be dubbed in Hindi, Tamil and Telugu.
"Much like how authentic and rooted Indian content resonates with audiences globally, Korean content has been demonstrating this time and again. While we started with content being made available with English dubbing and subtitles, the experience of watching a show dubbed in their language will now be much better for our regional audiences," said Manish Menghani, director and head, Content Licensing, Prime Video, India.
Shilangi Mukherji, director and head, SVOD business, Prime Video India, pointed out that Telugu-speaking viewers in particular, have been a significant audience and were among the factors that prompted them to explore platforming shows dubbed in other languages. "Compelling narratives, diverse genres, and memorable characters that transcend borders have fueled a K-content wave," she said.
Jang Ho Seo, executive vice president, Platform Division, CJ ENM, said that the partnership with the streaming platform in India was a reflection of their ongoing commitment to expand the global reach of K-Dramas.



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Hindi

Adil Hussain’s
antidote to
allergies



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Against the backdrop of a soft monsoon, *Max, Min & Meowzaki* unfolds as an elegant symphony of human vulnerability. At the heart of this coming-of-age, slice-of-life drama are three generations of single men, each carrying a heavy yet silent sorrow. They are men who have forgotten how to speak to one another. Yet to recover from the death of his mother, jingle singer Mahesh or Max (Siddharth Menon), is negotiating with the wreckage of a love story that has just collapsed into a bittersweet breakup with Minara Hussain, or Min (Medha Shankr). His father, Ramesh (Adil Hussain), a man tightly wound in rigid armour, is suffocating under a sleepless, unconfessed grief for his deceased wife and societal biases. The grandfather, an eminent Carnatic singer, Sridhar (Nassar) navigates the fading twilight of his memories, carrying a guilt of not being able to take his son along in the song of life.

When the relationship between Max and Min shatters, they argue over their belongings. The biggest battle is fought over Meowzaki, a rescued cat named in honour of Hayao Miyazaki. This beautiful, illogical choice becomes the catalyst for the entire family’s transformation.

Max shares his grief with an intuitive cat-sitter, Carol (Vidhatri Bandi), and Ramesh slowly sheds his defenses in a quiet therapy room to Reiki practitioner Dhaara (Mandira Bedi). Meanwhile, Sridhar finds a poetic piece of joy in an old age home alongside Jennifer (Nafisa Ali), a woman whose memory is slipping away.

Together, their intertwined journeys form a poignant narrative truth that healing is not about erasing the scars, but learning to breathe through the tenderness.

Director Padmakumar Narasimhamurthy subverts typical indie-drama expectations by weaving in complex social themes like communal prejudice, domestic violence, dementia and homosexuality, doing so with surprising restraint.

Meowzaki acts as a potent narrative anchor to convey the message: For Max, keeping a cat he is allergic to becomes a physical manifestation of dealing with discomfort, understanding the other, and processing grief rather than running away from it. Healing acts as the central mechanism that drives both the plot and the underlying emotional commentary as Padmakumar illustrates that moving forward requires individuals to confront the exact things they are running away from.

The dialogues are not always organic, but the music is catchy, built on a soothing blend of modern rock and classical roots. Gradually, the air of self-consciousness thickens as the eagerness to address ongoing political polarisation threatens to drown out internal voices.

Max, Min And Meowzaki is currently running in theatres.



An overstuffed crowd-pleaser

Vijay’s farewell film is in equal parts a crowd-pleasing tribute and a political manifesto, wrapped within an uneven but engaging masala entertainer

Tamil

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Ideas are bulletproof. Cinema is an idea charged with the power of a thousand dreams. And, if the recent past few months are proof of anything, one film star can change the lives of millions and alter reality as we see it.

After months-long troubles in the release due to controversies surrounding the issuance of a censor certificate, a legal battle, and a piracy attack, *Jana Nayagan* finally arrived in theatres. The film bids adieu to one of Tamil cinema’s most beloved stars, actor-turned-politician ‘Thalapathy’ Vijay, as the star himself announced during his election campaign. The introductory card shows a popular move Vijay pulled off in the TN Assembly weeks after becoming the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, and the cheers it garnered say enough about what this political actioner wishes to be.

Filled with meta-political references, hat-tips to MGR, and fan service, filmmaker H Vinoth’s *Jana Nayagan* celebrates the masala cinema that boosted Vijay as the hero of the masses. The film is a remake of Nandamuri Balakrishna’s 2023 film *Bhagavanth Kesari*, which told the story of a former cop raising a young girl and making her strong enough to join the Indian Army. Stepping into the theatre, it becomes evident what Vijay might have seen in the template of *Bhagavanth Kesari*: a father-and-daughter arc that speaks of women empowerment, hidden identity and family sentiment. With suitable action pay-offs and a strong political core, this has been designed to be the story of a saviour of democracy.

Cleverer than this is Vijay’s decision to rope in director H Vinoth; a fan of commercial cinema with acute political takes, Vinoth sees the many strengths of the story and screenplay of *Bhagavanth Kesari* and re-engineers it into a good-natured movie clearly crafted to bolster Vijay’s image as a political leader. On one hand, we follow the story of Viji

Jana
Nayagan

Director: H Vinoth

Cast: Vijay, Mamitha Baiju, Bobby Deol, Pooja Hedge, and others

Storyline: A convict takes guardianship of his late friend’s daughter while confronting a powerful extremist who threatens the future of India’s democracy.

(Mamitha Baiju), a young woman who suffers from trauma-induced phobias that cripple her with fear. After the untimely death of her father, Inspector Srikanth (Gautham Menon), a cop-turned-convict named Thalapathy Vetri Kondan (the name tells us enough), vows to realise her father’s dream to mould her into an Indian Army officer.

Another arc begins simultaneously when we are introduced to Bobby Deol’s antagonist, the menacing John Himmler, a threat that finds itself at Thalapathy’s doorstep. John threatens to destroy India’s democracy by instilling religious hatred. This layer explores the angle of standing up against political fear and bigotry, and while this arc makes *Jana Nayagan* uniquely its own, it also ends up becoming its biggest challenge.

Right from the first act, the screenplay impatiently brushes through several events at breakneck speed, thus losing much of the necessary emotional heft needed to anchor this story. In *Bhagavanth Kesari*, the first act where the child with a fear phobia gets adopted by the protagonist moves swiftly. In *Jana Nayagan*, this happens at an even brisker pace, everything transpiring in less than a few minutes. Thankfully, Anirudh Ravichander’s ‘Kanne Maniye’ provides emotional gravitas to the found father-daughter relationship.

Now, while a lion’s share of ideas from *Bhagavanth Kesari* seems to be retained, a few weak tropes recur in the remake. Instead of bettering the template, the director sticks to recreating most of it, while also writing a lengthy third act surrounding John Himmler, which balloons the film to a whopping 183 minutes.

From an awkwardly placed good-touch-bad-touch advert to a superfluous romance with Pooja Hegde’s journalist character, many ideas do not feel earned in the narrative. The overstuffed narrative keeps shuttling from one idea to the next; on one hand, Deol’s John suffers from a split personality, while Thalapathy solves a million problems that come his way, be it villains lusting after his daughter, a misogynistic businessman with a marriage prospect, or a woman protesting under a Kannagi statue.

Everything under the sun can find a place in the world of *Jana Nayagan*.

When the screenplay eventually reaches the third act, *Jana Nayagan* truly shows what it is all about. It starts getting apparent which political enemy Vijay is battling. Though admittedly the star deserves praise for the film’s social message. If AR Murugadoss’ *Madharaasi* warned of a future where gun culture enters Tamil Nadu, director Vinoth paints a future where RC robots are used in political warfare. While the larger message is welcome, it is placed in an already jam-packed narrative. And with a real-life political leader positioned at its centre, it risks coming across as advertorial.

All that said, in his last feature film appearance, Vijay looks his best and carries the scenes with his undeniably gripping screen presence. From his signature chin swipe to his signature tongue-swirl, the film features many Vijay-esque moments that are sure to appease his ardent fans. Fan service is abundant in *Jana Nayagan*, from unique callbacks to past hits to a mind-numbing conversation with an AI-powered MGR; there’s enough and more to fuel social media chatter for a few weeks.

Towards the end of the long film, I realise that there were two ‘Jana Nayagans’ in theatre today.

One is a film that should have powered an actor-turned-politician’s political dreams (that he got to sit in the hot chair before the film’s release is a twist of fate).

But there is another ‘Jana Nayagan’ that can be found in theatres today – one that millions of fans have grown up watching. You will find it in the eyes of ardent cinema fans, for they see before them a young boy with eyes full of dreams who debuted in 1992 with *Naalaya Theerpu*. Thousands of young, ordinary boys saw in him a man who defied his naysayers and gave them a language to love, celebrate and express themselves. He danced like a charm, pulled off comedy and drama with ease, and built an identity that was uniquely his.

And regardless of how his farewell film fares, the story of how C.Joseph Vijay became Ilayathalapathy, and eventually, Thalapathy, is a blockbuster for the ages.

Jana Nayagan is currently running in theatres

A film that loses steam midway

Telugu

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It is unfair to analyse a film as two halves. In the case of debut director Ravi Namburii’s Telugu film *Chennai Love Story*, however, it becomes inevitable. Sai Rajesh, who has written the story, screenplay and produced the film, introduces a twist at the mid-point that changes how the audience is likely to perceive the film.

The film begins with Nivedita (Sri Gouri Priya) being deserted by her fiancé on the wedding day. Her friends are supportive. But rather than suggesting therapy when she gives in to emotional turmoil, they respect her personal space. She finds refuge in alcohol.

The Chennai setting lends the narrative a distinct charm with understated visual aesthetics. Considerable portions have been filmed outdoors, with the local trains, beach, breeze and rain



standing witness to her story.

There is visual imagery in the form of movie icons and dialogues referred to through posters and t-shirts, and Mani Sharma’s music is steeped in melodies that evoke the magic of Ilaiyaraaja. Sai Rajesh is an ardent fan of the maestro’s music, and this reflects throughout the film. Alongside a love story that brews gradually between Nivedita and Steven Shankar (Kiran Abbavaram), these portions also become the director’s and writer’s

love story to cinema.

Everything that defines Steven Shankar’s character is written with thought, to ensure setups and payoffs as the story progresses. Take his name, for instance. It is a reflection of him being a fan of directors Steven Spielberg and Shankar. In a passing scene, we see him take notes from a Hollywood film. In a later scene, a character tells him that his stories read like derivatives of other filmmakers’ works rather than shining with an

original voice.

The writing in these portions seems to stem from real-life observations and experiences of Sai Rajesh and Ravi Namburii, mirroring the plight of the nameless and faceless aspiring filmmakers for whom narrating a story itself is a win, even if the producer turns them down. It also brims with self-deprecating humour. Watch out for the dialogues that reflect the frequent conversations among filmmakers and movie buffs about the difference between Telugu and Tamil cinema and the underlying truth.

While at it, the writing cleverly draws attention to Steven’s real name and his encounter with someone at a beachside stall, which seems random at first but echoes later in the story. The love story, too, is written with care, ensuring neither of the two protagonists are judged or sidestepped.

Chennai Love Story is a treat to watch until the key plot twist, packing within it an emotional love story and filmmaking aspirations. Sai Rajesh particularly pays homage to

Mani Ratnam’s *Mouna Raagam*, and Mani Sharma’s score subtly but surely pays homage to Ilaiyaraaja’s iconic background score for that film.

After the intermission, however, it’s almost as though we are watching a different film. It can take a while to get past the suspension of disbelief.

The narrative hopes that the audience, having watched enough emotional love stories over the decades, will resonate with it. The old-world treatment given to the film thus far also accentuates this mood.

Chennai Love
Story

Director: Ravi Namburii

Cast: Sri Gouri Priya, Kiran Abbavaram

Storyline: Love, heartbreak, aspirations and healing take unexpected an turn in an unusual narrative

The beats of the story from this point become predictable. Some portions are intentionally funny, while others are unintentional. Some scenes test patience. The long duration doesn’t help either.

Chennai Love Story’s major strength is Sri Gouri Priya’s performance. She is astute in portraying the mix of vulnerability and steadfastness required for her character. Whether it’s heartbreak, being unapologetic in rage, or giving in to helplessness, she makes it all seem lived in. Kiran Abbavaram puts forth a measured, understated portrayal.

Had the writing taken a different, practical route post the intermission, perhaps we would have had a contemporary love story that dealt with trauma and moving on. But this film wants to be partly contemporary and partly old-world melodramatic. There lies its confusion. The result is a partly engaging film that doesn’t soar.

Chennai Love Story is currently in theatres.

Karavali

Director: Gurudatha Ganiga

Cast: Prajwal Devraj, Sampada Hulivana, Raj B Shetty, Mithra

Storyline: In coastal Karnataka, a revenge story unfolds as a fuedal lord is challenged by a gifted Kambala racer.



Stumbles before the finish line

Kannada

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Kambala, the high-speed buffalo-racing sport, had a small yet significant presence in Rishab Shetty's *Kantara* (2022). That movie used the sport as a tool to depict the fearless, fierce energy of its protagonist. Now, imagine a movie that revolves around Kambala – its politics and the rich history behind the century-old tradition – while giving as much importance to the animals as to the men who race them. That's exactly what director Gurdhatha Ganiga's *Karavali*

sets out to do.

In a picturesque town in coastal Karnataka, Ramesh Indira plays the feared 'Dhoddavaru', a man who wields authority over the village. A classic power-hungry patriarch. That explains why the Koti Chennaya Kambala has not taken place in the village for 30 years; whoever wins the race gets to the coveted *kurchi*, a seat representing absolute power.

Nobody dares to take on 'Dhoddavaru', until Dhananjay (Prajwal Devaraj), a gentle yet gifted youth, gets dragged into this politics. Dhananjay shares a special bond with the buffaloes, treating them with affection and taming them with gentleness.

Karavali is at its best when its dwells on subtle moments. The lead

romance, portrayed by Prajwal and Sampada Hulivana, may not leave a lasting impact, but its deft handling makes it watchable. The buffaloes are treated like members of the family. Even Raj B Shetty's extended cameo as Mahaveera is bolstered by tender moments. The absurd idea of a highly skilled Kambala racer falling for buffaloes more than women is conveyed with the right dose of humour. The actor's screen presence strengthens the episode.

There is a powerful scene involving Mahabala that lays bare the harsh realities of caste discrimination. But *Karavali* does not dig deep into this angle. Mithra's performance goes from understated to loud as *Karavali* unfolds into one melodramatic stretch after another. The story struggles to move forward, as it keeps circling the plot point of Mahabala wanting to avenge his massive personal loss.

Predictability is still not the biggest issue of *Karavali*.

It is the handling of the lead character. It is quite bizarre to see Prajwal's role being so out of place in the film's universe. He is a capable actor, but in this film, he never quite finds the measure of his character. The script has more high moments for Mahabala and Mahaveera, with Dhananjay made to go through the motions except for a few moments, including the climax.

The film was in the news for the wrong reasons in the lead-up to its release, with Prajwal crying foul over his remuneration not being paid and not being given a chance to dub his voice.

Ganiga attempts to tell a complex story and makes the most of it by transporting you to a different world thanks to his solid technicians. But *Karavali* fails to leave you with an emotional high.

Karavali is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Pankaj Tripathi to receive Artist of Distinction award at IFFM 2026

Actor Pankaj Tripathi will be honoured with the Artist of Distinction award at the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne 2026.

As per a press release, the honour will be presented to celebrate the actor's "exceptional contribution to Indian cinema and his remarkable journey as one of the country's most respected performers". This will also be the first time the National Award-winning actor will attend the festival and receive the honour in Melbourne, Australia.

The festival will take place in Melbourne, Austrailia from August 13-23. It will bring together a diverse line-up of films, filmmakers, actors and industry talent from across India and the world.



Prithviraj Sukumaran's action thriller *Khalifa* to release on this date

A new poster of *Khalifa*, an action-thriller starring Prithviraj Sukumaran, was unveiled via the actor's Instagram handle on July 27. The film, directed by Vysakh and produced by Jinu V Abraham and Suraj Kumar, is set to release on August 20.

The film, with the tagline, "Vengeance will be written in gold," is also penned by Jinu. In the poster, the protagonist is seen walking with an entourage with the Burj Al Arab hotel in Dubai in the backdrop. Prithviraj plays Aamir Ali, a gold smuggler in the film. Veteran actor Mohanlal plays Mambarakkal Ahmed Ali, Aamir's grandfather, in the film, which will release in two parts.



Season 2 of Karan Johar's reality show *The Traitors* gets release date

Streaming service Prime Video announced the release date of the season 2 of Karan Johar-hosted reality show, *The Traitors* on July 27. It will be released on the streamer on August 13 with new episodes arriving every Thursday.

An Indian adaptation of the international reality show, *The Traitors* features 21 celebrity players contesting for the grand prize. The show is produced by Johar's Dharmatic Entertainment in collaboration with independent distributor All3Media International for the local adaptation of the format that has been made in 40 territories across the world.

The first season aired from June 12 to July 3 last year.



A colossal political epitaph

Hajime Isayama's monumental saga remains one of this century's most incisive examinations of why the struggle for freedom never belongs to a single generation

Japanese

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It is difficult to imagine a more appropriate moment for *Attack on Titan* to return. Its long-awaited release on Indian screens, feels almost preordained. The National Capital has already witnessed a wave of student protests faced with state violence and dehumanising responses to dissent. Standing before an apparatus that appears immeasurably larger than ourselves, the prospect of liberation from injustice and tyranny can seem permanently deferred. But freedom is a pure idea, and few works of fiction have interrogated what that word truly demands with comparable clarity or conviction as Hajime Isayama's seminal epic.

For those new to the anime, the story initially presents itself as a straightforward survival thriller. Humanity's last survivors live behind three enormous concentric walls that shield them from the Titans, gigantic humanoid creatures whose inexplicable appetite for human flesh has driven civilisation to the brink of extinction. *The Last Attack* is director Yuichiro Hayashi's 145-minute theatrical reconstruction of studio MAPPA's conclusion to the anime adaptation.

Anyone who has had the misfortune of being accosted by an otaku has almost certainly been prescribed *Attack on Titan* as anime's definitive gateway drug, usually accompanied by unwavering confidence that Isayama has produced either one of the greatest stories ever told or the most politically incisive work the medium has ever offered (or both). I belong to that same stubborn congregation of converts, first mesmerised by the sheer scope of Isayama's storytelling, becoming fascinated by the political architecture holding every twist together.

There is plenty to admire about the film as a piece of filmmaking, from

Attack on Titan: The Last Attack

Director: Yuichiro Hayashi

Cast: Yuki Kaji, Romi Park, Hiroshi Kamiya, Yui Ishikawa, Marina Inoue, Takehito Koyasu

Storyline: The fate of the world hangs in the balance as Eren unleashes the ultimate power of the Titans. With a burning determination to eliminate all who threaten Eldia, he leads an unstoppable army of Colossal Titans towards Marley.

MAPPA's refined presentation to the overwhelming force of its audiovisual scale, but spending the next few hundred words cataloguing those achievements would leave the work's most fascinating accomplishment untouched. Which is why I'd rather use this review as an opportunity to briefly examine what Isayama's story has been building towards, reflected through the political anxieties of our time.

The temptation has always been to decode *Attack on Titan* as a cipher for one historical atrocity or another, but Isayama's ideological imagination operates with far greater sophistication. The political parallels woven throughout the story are too deliberate to dismiss and too expansive to reduce to any single historical analogue. Be it the racial state engineered by Nazi Germany, the imperial mythology that sustained Japanese expansionism, or even the dehumanisation of Palestinians through Israel's occupation that frames ethnonationalism as an existential necessity, Isayama's concerns consistently return to how political systems institutionalise fear and gradually persuade ordinary people that extraordinary violence constitutes the final guarantor of peace.

Eren, Mikasa, Armin and every young recruit who joins the Survey Corps begin their journey carrying the simple desire to live without fear and inherit a future untouched by violence, but their childhood disappears beneath an endless succession of catastrophes. Their trajectories are political consequences of a generation raised beneath permanent existential terror. Fascism recognises the vulnerability of childhood trauma with frightening efficiency because it converts grief into identity, identity into exclusion and exclusion into righteous violence until extermination feels like the only way out.

Every project of political tyranny begins with teaching successive generations whose humanity can be indefinitely suspended in service of the state. More often than not, children are its first casualties – if the mounting death toll of thousands of Palestinian children and infants in Gaza still fails to convey the

catastrophic human cost of that logic, one need only look closer to home at what transpired at Delhi's Jantar Mantar to witness how the apathy of an authoritarian state repeatedly sacrifices its youth at the altar of preserving power and protecting vested interests.

Yet, despite every attempt to curb-stomp humanity's most fundamental instinct to live freely, *Attack on Titan* never relinquishes its faith in the indomitable human spirit. Isayama repeatedly returns to how the stubborn desire to live freely survives every apparatus designed to smother it. Every attempt to discipline those impulses through terror, propaganda or inherited hatred ultimately encounters people willing to wager their own lives against history's apparent inevitability. Hange's heartbreaking final stand, Erwin's impossible march towards certain death and every nameless Scout who charges into battle knowing they will never witness the world they are fighting to create, collectively reject the authoritarian fantasy that history belongs exclusively to the powerful. Their sacrifices do not guarantee victory, nor do they redeem the unimaginable losses that precede them, yet each act of martyrdom extends the political horizon a little further for those left behind.

The idea of freedom in *Attack on Titan* therefore, is an inheritance painstakingly assembled through generations who accept that they may never enjoy its rewards themselves. Though Isayama's closing images gesture towards the terrifying possibility that history remains trapped within an endless cycle of violence, they never suppress the series' belief that humanity will continue resisting that inevitability. His deepest faith ultimately resides in the base human conviction that oppression can postpone liberation for decades, even centuries, but it cannot permanently extinguish the instinct that first compelled frightened children to look beyond the walls and imagine a different future.

Shinzo wo Sasageyo. Long live the revolution.

Attack on Titan: The Last Attack is currently running in theatres